



Lighting the way home

Four days into the battle, wounded soldiers of the First Cavalry watch flares from planes light up a field in the Ia Drang Valley. Bodies of wounded and fallen soldiers alike were taken to this clearing to await evacuation by helicopter.

On the move

The fighting at LZ X-Ray lasted for two days and nights, as US forces repulsed attack after attack by NVA infantry advancing in waves. Eventually, enough reinforcements arrived to even up the numbers of soldiers on each side, and LZ X-Ray was secured on day three—but at heavy cost. The remaining US units abandoned the area to make way for a B-52 strike, then marched toward a new landing zone, LZ Albany, just over 2 miles (3 km) away. NVA forces ambushed the column en route, resulting in a new round of vicious combat.

Men who had already endured three days of combat now found themselves fighting in close quarters, sometimes hand to hand, for 16 hours. The tide finally turned on November 19, thanks to reinforcements and artillery and air strikes—so close to US lines that they caused friendly fire casualties.

Both sides bore heavy losses in the battle: nearly 300 Americans were killed and hundreds more were wounded, while the NVA had perhaps 500 to 1,000 dead and as many wounded.